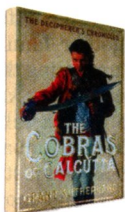


# A Traitor's TALE

A mix of fact and fiction produces a thriller set at the start of British dominance of India

By Dilip Bobb



THE COBRAS OF CALCUTTA  
by GRANT SUTHERLAND  
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The worst insult in India is to be referred to as Mir Jafar. Jafar ranks that high as a baddie because he is labelled Ghaddar-e-Hind (Traitor of India). He was commander to Siraj-ud-Daulah, the nawab of Bengal, and succeeded him through treachery by surrendering his army in the Battle of Plassey against Robert Clive. That one act of treason is widely considered the start of British rule in India and their eventual domination of the country.

That forms the backdrop to this fictional tale of adventure, espionage and military conquests in Bengal, the commercial foothold that the British and the French were competing for. This is also the first in *The Decipherer's Chronicles*, a historical spy series introducing Alistair Douglas, a British agent during the Napoleonic period. The events leading to the Battle of Plassey and Mir Jafar's role, along with many others, have been well recorded. What Sutherland does is to dress up fact with fiction and introduce the forerunner to James Bond, Douglas, a young man who represents the covert institution of the Decipherers or analysers of intelligence. The institution is fictitious but people like Douglas would have been useful, even necessary, in a situation where Britain was locked in deadly, and silent combat with its greatest enemy, France.

Bengal was crucial to their respective ambitions in India, commercial and colonial. Calcutta was the financial capital of India and the nawab of Bengal was being aided and wooed by both sides. The British were alarmed at the growing French influence—they had a base in Chandernagore and even lent the nawab French soldiers to operate artillery. The French guns captured at the Battle of Plassey can still be seen at the Victoria Memorial in Calcutta and the French influence is still extant in what is now Chandannagar. That rivalry is what Sutherland exploits to spin out his tale of tinker, tailors, soldiers and spies.

Douglas is no James Bond. It is more through accident that he actually sees action in the battles and skirmishes. Sutherland produces a rollicking adventure story based on the events of the time—the capture of British-held Fort William in Calcutta by the nawab's army, the infamous Black Hole of Calcutta, the intrigues that led to the decisive Battle of Plassey and Mir Jafar's reward for his treachery. In what is essentially a historical thriller, Sutherland brings in the other characters who played such a key role at the time: the rich banker Jagat Seth, the merchant Omichund (Amir Chand), apart from Clive, Warren Hastings and the man who played the biggest part in getting Mir Jafar to turn traitor, William Watts, the head of the British factory at Cossimbazar.

This is a classic adventure story that blends fact and fiction in a format that Sutherland has used in his earlier book on the Gulf War. Where Sutherland falters is in affording his hero, Douglas, a rather passive role, only occasionally firing a weapon in anger. Even his spying activities are not very clearly defined. His main contribution lies in sketching scenes and battles and his relations with some French officers. He does make his presence felt in the sense of being present when history-making decisions are being taken, and becoming a trusted aide to Watts and by extension, Clive, but more as an observer and recorder than active participant. Even the romantic angle (he falls for Watts' wife) hardly figures except as a minor diversion from the main story. For all that, this is an engaging, if fictional, twist to a decisive period in Indian history when treachery and intrigue led to the end of one empire and the birth of another. ■

